

What is it?

A PhD literature review is a critical assessment of the literature in your field and related to your specific research topic.

What should it include?

The job of a literature review is to show five things:

1. What has been written on your topic
2. Who the key authors are and what the key works are
3. The main theories and hypotheses
4. The main themes that exist in the literature
5. Gaps and weaknesses that your study will then help fill

Make sure it:

1. Provides sufficient background information so that your own research problem can be contextualised
2. Discusses how, how well, or even if others have solved similar problems
3. Outlines the methods used by others when discussing similar problems
4. Is either structured chronologically or thematically

What should you avoid?

- Don't drown in a sea of authors
- Don't just summarise texts, be critical of them
- Don't spend too long reviewing the literature at the expense of conducting fieldwork
- Don't be mean. Being critical is not the same as being mean.

How can you make it great?

- Remember to always be critical
- Speak with authority
- Read an article through once without taking notes, then read it again while making notes
- Think like a detective. Understand what others have written, why, and how it relates to your study.
- Don't take everything at face value. Be critical of it.

How does it relate to other chapters?

- For your own study to make sense, it has to be situated in the literature. That means you must relate it to what others are talking about.
- The literature review will provide context for your research questions, aims and objective, and will lead naturally into your theory framework discussion.
- The literature review provides the intellectual family tree for your study, situating it in the broader context of a particular field or discipline.

Notes:



What is it?

In the literature review you highlighted the problem that needs 'fixing'. The theoretical framework is the 'toolbox' you use. It details the theories, propositions, hypotheses (if you're using them) and concepts - the 'tools' - that you will use to address or make sense of this problem.

What should you avoid?

- Avoid combining theories that share different epistemological or ontological underpinnings.
- Avoid writing or introducing your theory framework descriptively. Always be critical.
- Read first hand material and avoid other people's reviews of theories where possible.
- Don't rely too heavily on quotes. Your examiner wants to see that you can understand the theory.
- Avoid claiming that your theory is perfect or 100% reliable. It won't be and you should acknowledge its limitations.

Notes:

What should it include?

The job of a theoretical framework chapter is to discuss in detail what the tools look like, how they behave, how they have been used before, how they relate to one another, how they are relevant to your aims and objectives and what the drawbacks are from using them.

The key when writing your theoretical framework is to show your understanding of the broad theoretical school and to define the key concepts, both with reference to the existing literature, but also to your research questions and problem statement. Make sure you have covered the following:

1. You need to have a solid grasp of your aims and objectives. These define the space in which your research will sit and your goals when conducting it. You will need to briefly recap these when you start writing your theoretical framework, both to remind the reader and so that you can relate your theory to these overarching aims.
2. Critically explain the theory/theories you are using.
3. Critically argue why you are adopting this particular theory/combination of theories.
4. Can the theory/theories be broken down into different schools? Explain the one you are siding with and why.
5. A theory contains a number of concepts. Explain those that you will be drawing upon and clearly define them. Outline any hypotheses you use.
6. Explain your epistemological and ontological position, and how it influences the way in which you use and apply theory.
7. Have you explained how the concepts/hypotheses relate to your aims and objectives?
8. Are you the first to use this particular theory in this particular way? Explain the benefits and drawbacks that this brings.
9. Explain the drawbacks of applying this theory.

How can you make it great?

- When discussing the theory/theories you are using, define and explain each theory you draw upon and, in doing so, discuss the leading proponents and applications. This shows that you understand the theory you are going to adopt.
- When discussing why you are adopting a particular theory/combination of theories, There are a lot of potential theories you could use. Why this one? Importantly, you should relate your choice to the discussions in the literature review and your aims and objectives.
- Explain how the concepts are related to to one another, whether in the form of models or hypotheses.

How does it relate to other chapters?

The theoretical framework is a natural extension of the literature review. The purpose of the literature review, amongst other things, is to highlight gaps and shortcomings with the existing work in your field. The theoretical framework details the perspective you will take to address those gaps and shortcomings.



Literature Review

This is where you make the case for your research and discuss its academic heritage. The job of a literature review is to firmly ground the study in the existing body of work. Answering the questions below will help you do this and provide you with a synopsis of the chapter. What questions need more work?

What are the most important authors, findings, concepts, schools, debates and hypotheses?

What gaps exist in the literature?

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Are these gaps methodological, conceptual or epistemological?

How does your thesis fill these gaps?

Theoretical Framework

You may or may not have a dedicated theory framework section, but if you do, it needs to discuss the toolbox of concepts, hypotheses, variables, and so on, you will use. Answer the questions below to sketch out your framework. Which of the questions can you not yet answer?

What theoretical concepts are used in the research?

What hypotheses, if any, are you using?

Why have you chosen this theory?

What are the implications of using this theory?

Theoretical Framework

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How does the theory relate to the existing literature, your problem statement and your epistemological and ontological positions?

**How has this theory has been applied by others in similar contexts?
What can you learn from them and how do you differ?**

**How do you apply the theory and measure the concepts
(with reference to the literature review/problem statement)?**

**What is the relationship between the various elements and concepts
within the model? Can you depict this visually?**